

World in Brief: Paramount delays Warner Bros merger; Houthis and Saudi Arabia fight



Photograph: Getty Images

Paramount Skydance agreed to delay its [\\$111bn merger](#) with **Warner Bros Discovery** until June 2027 at the latest, while a judge considers the legal merits of an antitrust lawsuit against the tie-up. Twelve American states [have sued to halt the megadeal](#), alleging it would give the combined company greater leverage over cinemas and cable distributors. Paramount said these claims “cannot withstand scrutiny”.

The **Houthis**, a Yemeni militia, claimed to have struck Jizan, a city in Saudi Arabia, with missiles on Friday. Earlier Saudi Arabia attacked Houthi targets in Hodeida, a port city, in retaliation for the militants firing on tankers in the Red Sea. [Donald Trump](#) has said that he will hold Iran, which backs the group, responsible for its actions. He has threatened “major military punishment”.

The governments of **France** and **Spain** ordered more than 200,000 people to evacuate as **wildfires** raged. France has mobilised the armed forces to fight blazes near Bordeaux, in the southwest. Spain declared a national emergency as several fires merged outside Madrid. Spanish officials have warned that the conflagration is “beyond the capacity” of firefighters.

Mr Trump threatened **Europe** with another “substantial” tariff and promised an investigation into the bloc’s penalising of American tech companies. This week the European Commission fined Google €890m (\$1bn) for allegedly prioritising its own products in its search and preventing apps from directing users towards cheaper offers via other app stores. Other American tech giants, including Apple and Meta, have been hit with [similar penalties](#).

Member states of the **International Criminal Court** voted to fire **Karim Khan**, its chief prosecutor, over allegations of sexual misconduct (which he denies). The decision comes as the court separately faces pressure from America, which is not a member, related to [its investigations](#) into American and Israeli citizens. Marco Rubio, America’s secretary of state, recently launched a campaign to “dismantle” the ICC.

America reported its highest number of **measles** infections in 35 years. The Centres for Disease Control and Prevention confirmed 2,318 cases so far this year, overtaking the 2,289 [counted in 2025](#), a previous record. It also warned that [vaccination rates](#) are falling among young children. Measles was declared “eliminated” in America in 2000; the latest outbreak could threaten that status.

SpaceX completed the 13th flight of its **Starship** reusable rocket. It is the first big test of Elon Musk’s rocket-and-AI conglomerate since its blockbuster initial public offering in June. The rocket’s splashdown was so gentle that its booster phase floated on the ocean rather than exploding, as some previous versions have. SpaceX described it as its best re-entry yet.

Figure of the day: \$1trn, the amount wiped off SpaceX’s market value since its post-IPO peak of \$2.6trn. [Read](#) our interview with Elon Musk, the rocketry firm’s owner and world’s richest man.

The Middle Eastern oil shock, Houthi edition



Photograph: Getty Images

After America and Iran agreed to reopen the Strait of Hormuz in June, the price of Brent crude fell to nearly \$70 a barrel. But after 13 nights of American strikes on Iran, the global oil-price benchmark hit triple digits again, before dropping slightly on Friday.

It could stay there for a while. [Traffic through Hormuz](#) has petered out since Iran resumed attacking tankers and America reimposed its embargo on the country's ports. This week Yemeni Houthi rebels declared a blockade of Saudi Arabian ports in the Red Sea; the kingdom had rerouted its oil exports to Asia, about two-thirds of the total, through that waterway. So far the Houthis have attacked two ships; more have turned back.

Meanwhile, Ukrainian drone strikes on Russia's energy infrastructure continue to disrupt its fuel exports, too. The crunch is worst in refined products: prices of petrol, diesel and jet fuel have all reached their highest level in months. The [biggest oil-supply shock](#) in history just got bigger.

India's young cockroaches

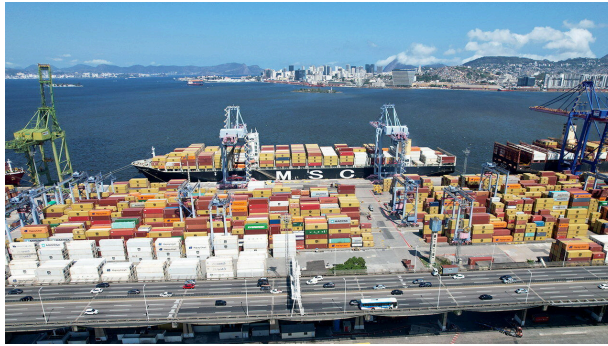


Photograph: Shutterstock

Three months ago the Cockroach Janta Party did not exist. This week the Gen-Z movement was behind Delhi's biggest protest in more than half a decade. The CJP began as a joke in response to a comment by India's Supreme Court chief justice comparing unemployed young people to cockroaches. Over the past week the group's supporters have taken to the streets across the country in largely peaceful protests.

Young people are outraged over a recent leak of entrance exam papers. But underneath is a deeper anger: the world's largest youth population endures gruelling challenges to enter too few good universities, only to graduate into a poor job market. Narendra Modi's government seems to have been taken by surprise at the strength of feeling. The protesters have rallied around a [hunger striker](#), Sonam Wangchuk, whom authorities dragged off to hospital. On Friday he announced he was calling off his fast following assurances that the protesters would not be punished. But that has done little to stop them. They have vowed to remain on the streets until their main demand—that the education minister resigns—is met. India's cockroaches will not be easily crushed.

Donald Trump's beastly tariffs



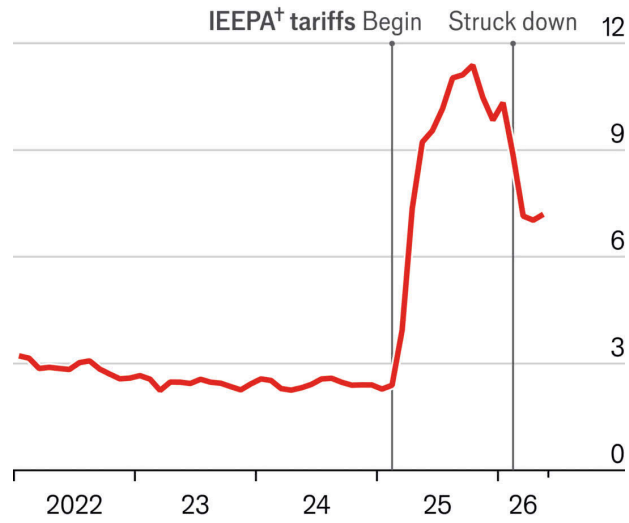
Photograph: Getty Images

After it was decapitated by America's Supreme Court, Donald Trump's [hydra-like tariff regime](#) is sprouting new heads. On Monday the President invoked an obscure law to impose 50% duties on some Canadian goods, claiming it was in retaliation to discrimination against American cars, alcohol and dairy. The levies, which cover nearly \$20bn of imports, will not take effect until August 19th, seemingly to provide leverage in stalled trade talks.

On Friday a separate 10% global tariff on most imports reached its 150-day limit and expired. Replacements have come into place. The administration announced duties of between 10% and 12.5% on 60 economies failing to police imports of goods made with forced labour. More are expected later this year on big trading partners blamed for slowing America's manufacturing revival by overproducing goods. Together the measures would recreate Mr Trump's old tariff schedule, and many trade lawyers expect them to last. It will take more to slay the beast.

Barriers to entry

US, average effective tariff rate*, %



*As observed in customs data

[†]International Emergency Economic Powers Act

Source: University of Pennsylvania Wharton Budget Model

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: The ILCA 7, ILCA 6 and Mixed 470 are Olympic categories for racing which kind of boat?

Thursday: What is the common British term for a bed surrounded by bars and designed for a baby or small child?

The art of victory is learned in defeat.

Simón Bolívar